

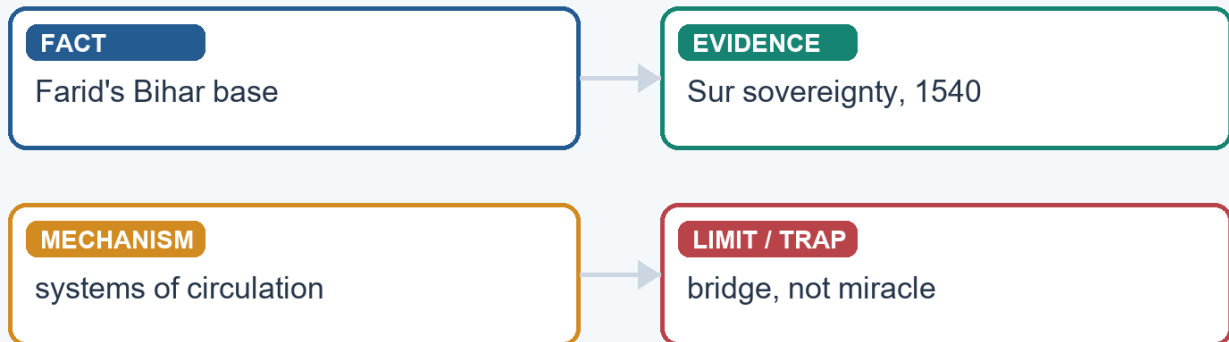
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Sher Shah Sur & the Sur Empire - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Sher Shah Sur and the Sur Empire

A short reign with a long administrative afterlife



TOPIC 14 VISUAL 00 | Deterministic schematic; explanatory labels, not a scale map or a primary-source quotation.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Sher Shah Sur & the Sur Empire - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

PART I. Learning MCQ loops: 18 questions

Correct-option audit: ABCDABCDABCDABCDAB.

Q1. The safest description of Farid's early political formation is that he:

- A. gained administrative exposure in his father's jagirs and parganas before rising in Bihar politics.
- B. was born as the hereditary emperor of a settled Sur state.
- C. entered India only after the Battle of Panipat II.
- D. was appointed the first Mughal subedar of Bengal by Akbar.

Answer: A. Explanation: Farid's experience in local assignments explains why revenue, local intermediaries and Bihar politics matter in his later rise. The closest distractor is B: it turns a mobile noble's career into hereditary imperial succession.

Q2. Surajgarh is most useful in this topic because it marks:

- A. Humayun's restoration to Delhi in 1555.
- B. the scaling-up of Sher Khan's Bihar-centred power against Bengal in 1534.
- C. the permanent annexation of Kashmir by Sher Shah.
- D. Akbar's introduction of dahsala in 1580.

Answer: B. Explanation: Surajgarh belongs to the Bihar-Bengal scale-up that preceded Sur sovereignty. The nearest error is C: Humayun's restoration occurred much later and has no connection with this 1534 encounter.

Q3. Which sequence is chronologically sound?

- A. Kalinjar -> Chausa -> Babur's Panipat.
- B. Samel -> Chausa -> Sikandar Lodi's death.
- C. Chausa -> Kannauj -> Sher Shah's formal sovereignty.
- D. Humayun's return -> Chausa -> Islam Shah's accession.

Answer: C. Explanation: Chausa (1539) preceded Kannauj (1540), after which Sher Shah ruled north India. The closest distractor is D, which reverses the Sur-Mughal chronology by placing the 1555 return first.

Q4. A map of the Sur empire should explicitly qualify that:

- A. only Bihar and Bengal were ruled.
- B. Kashmir was the Sur capital.
- C. the empire was an exact modern provincial rectangle.
- D. Kashmir was excluded even though the realm broadly ran from Bengal to the Indus.

Answer: D. Explanation: The source's Bengal-to-Indus formulation is qualified by the exclusion of Kashmir. The closest distractor is A, which imports modern boundary precision into a medieval campaign-and-corridor empire.

Q5. Satish Chandra's caution about Sher Shah's reputation chiefly requires us to:

- A. treat him as part of a longer process of north Indian unification, while recognising implementation.
- B. call Akbar the first user of revenue measurement.
- C. accept every praise passage in Sarwani as an audit report.
- D. deny that any Sur institution functioned.

Answer: A. Explanation: The point is neither dismissal nor hero worship: Sher Shah systematised within a longer process. The closest distractor is C, which ignores the genre and retrospective limits of courtly praise.

Q6. Why is it unsafe to call Sher Shah's realm a modern direct bureaucratic state?

- A. It possessed elected legislatures.
- B. It depended on personal supervision, assignments and local intermediaries.
- C. It had no roads or coins.
- D. It abolished all military service.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sur rule worked through a strong sovereign and mediated local structures, not a modern impersonal bureaucracy. The closest distractor is A because roads and coinage were precisely among the visible Sur measures.

Q7. Which is the best territorial-administration formulation?

- A. Sher Shah divided the empire into twelve subas in 1540.
- B. Each village was a modern district directly ruled from Delhi.
- C. Sarkar/shiq, pargana and village mediation were important; avoid projecting Akbar's subas backward.
- D. Pargana was a synonym for the whole empire.

Answer: C. Explanation: This preserves both territorial vocabulary and the Akbar boundary. The closest distractor is A: the twelve-subas reference belongs to Akbar's later system.

Q8. The position of zamindars and village headmen under Sher Shah is best described as:

- A. entirely abolished by patta.
- B. identical to British collectors.
- C. outside all revenue activity.
- D. central to mediation, assessment and policing, though subject to control and punishment.

Answer: D. Explanation: Intermediaries remained indispensable even when the state sought record and discipline. The closest distractor is A, which mistakes a revenue record for elimination of local power.

Q9. Sher Shah's revenue chain begins most accurately with:

- A. measurement of sown land followed by classification and average yield calculation.
- B. a fixed modern cadastral survey.
- C. a permanent ten-year cash settlement.
- D. automatic confiscation of all village land.

Answer: A. Explanation: The source sequence moves from sown-land measurement to good/middling/bad classification and an average. The closest distractor is A: ten-year averaging is associated with Akbar's dahsala, not a Sur permanent settlement.

Q10. In the Sur revenue discussion, rai refers most safely to:

- A. a category of permanently fallow land.
- B. crop rates used in calculating an assessable demand.
- C. a cavalry branding mark.
- D. a modern elected village council.

Answer: B. Explanation: Rai is the crop-rate element in the assessment logic. The closest distractor is D: dagh, not rai, concerns the verification of horses.

Q11. A patta in this topic is evidence of:

- A. the abolition of all local headmen.
- B. a religious decree against merchants.
- C. a recorded statement of area, crop and amount due, not a modern ryotwari system.
- D. a fort built near the Indus.

Answer: C. Explanation: The patta makes demand more knowable but does not dissolve local mediation or create a colonial-era settlement. The closest distractor is B, which overreads documentation as social transformation.

Q12. Which revenue qualification is source-safe?

- A. Multan was Sher Shah's capital.
- B. Assessment did not use any local knowledge.
- C. Every crop in every place paid the same verified rate.
- D. The one-third share was generally stated, while practice remained mediated and the Multan exception cautions against uniformity.

Answer: D. Explanation: One-third is a general principle, not a universal spreadsheet; the Multan exception blocks totalising claims. The closest distractor is A, which manufactures precision absent from the evidence.

Q13. Sher Shah's chief road contribution is best phrased as:

- A. restoring and improving an older Indus-Sonargaon imperial route later called the GT Road.
- B. replacing every road with river transport.
- C. building only a Delhi-Agra ceremonial avenue.
- D. inventing all roads in north India from nothing.

Answer: A. Explanation: The historical claim is restoration/improvement of an older route. The closest distractor is A, the standard invention myth that ignores prior imperial corridors.

Q14. Why should two-karoh/four-mile wording be retained cautiously?

- A. It proves a 2,000-kilometre road.
- B. It is a historical spacing description and should not be converted into fake exact kilometres.
- C. It means every sarai had two armies.
- D. It names a tax rate.

Answer: B. Explanation: The wording tells us about regular interval planning, not a modern survey conversion. The closest distractor is A, which converts a local interval into an impossible total-road claim.

Q15. Sarais are most analytically significant as:

- A. welfare shelters with no fiscal or political role.
- B. modern railway stations.
- C. nodes of lodging, markets, relay, military movement, trade and surveillance.
- D. single-purpose religious buildings.

Answer: C. Explanation: A sarai concentrated travellers, goods, news and oversight, making it a circulation node. The closest distractor is A, which erases the military and surveillance dimensions.

Q16. Customs simplification under Sher Shah should be stated as:

- A. a fixed 10 per cent tariff in every town.
- B. abolition of every tax in the empire.
- C. a system applied only in Kashmir.
- D. duties at entry and sale with simplified levies, without inventing rates.

Answer: D. Explanation: The source supports a simplification claim, not fabricated numerical tariffs. The closest distractor is C, which supplies an unsupported rate and falsely universalises it.

Q17. The silver rupee claim is safest when it says:

- A. Sher Shah standardised a fine silver rupee; earlier silver coins existed.
- B. gold coinage vanished immediately.
- C. the rupee had no effect beyond his camp.
- D. Sher Shah invented money.

Answer: A. Explanation: Standardisation is the achievement; earlier silver currency prevents an invention myth. The closest distractor is A, which confuses a coin standard with the origin of money.

Q18. Which statement correctly traces dagh and chehra?

- A. Sher Shah abolished all horse inspection.

- B. Alauddin used them, Sher Shah revived/adapted them, and Akbar systematised them.
- C. They were a road-tax system.
- D. Akbar invented both before Alauddin's reign.

Answer: B. Explanation: The three-stage provenance is the key discriminator. The closest distractor is A because it deletes the Sultanate precedent that Topic 07 explicitly preserves.

PART II. Broad practice: 40 questions

Correct-option audit: **ABCD x 10.**

Q1. Rohtas in the northwest is associated with

- A. the Bihar hill-fort Rohtasgarh.
- B. collecting customs at Sonargaon.
- C. controlling Gakhars and checking a possible Mughal incursion.
- D. the later Mughal suba headquarters at Agra.

Answer: C. Explanation: Rohtas in the north-west is a Gakhhar/Mughal-check fort; Rohtasgarh is the closest trap because its similar name places it in Bihar.

Q2. Rohtasgarh should not be conflated with

- A. the north-western Rohtas associated with Gakhars.
- B. Kalinjar in Bundelkhand.
- C. Chunar near the Bihar approach.
- D. Rohtas in present-day Pakistan.

Answer: D. Explanation: The geographic discriminator is decisive: Rohtasgarh is a Bihar fort, whereas north-western Rohtas is the Sur frontier work.

Q3. Samel (1544) belongs to

- A. the Rajasthan campaign field associated with Maldeo's forces.
- B. Humayun's restoration campaign in Punjab.
- C. the siege in which Sher Shah died at Kalinjar.
- D. Akbar's Gujarat campaign.

Answer: A. Explanation: Samel belongs to the Rajasthan campaign and is linked to Maldeo's field, not to a later Mughal recovery or Kalinjar.

Q4. Puran Mal/Raisen should be read as

- A. a complete record of uniform Sur religious law.
- B. a violent political act with religious gloss, not evidence of uniform policy.
- C. a routine revenue settlement with cultivators.
- D. proof that no violence occurred in Sur expansion.

Answer: B. Explanation: The evidence requires both political calculation and acknowledged violence; the uniform-policy option overgeneralises one episode.

Q5. Sher Shah died during

- A. Humayun's return to Delhi in 1555.
- B. the Chausa battle in 1539.
- C. the siege of Kalinjar in 1545.
- D. the Samel campaign in 1544.

Answer: C. Explanation: Kalinjar, not Chausa or Samel, is the 1545 siege in which Sher Shah died.

Q6. Islam Shah's centralisation illustrates

- A. Akbar's later mansabdari ranking.
- B. the abandonment of monarchical supervision.

- C. a permanent reconciliation of every Afghan chief.
- D. monarchical assertion that could heighten Afghan noble resentment.

Answer: D. Explanation: Islam Shah's policy asserted monarchy over nobles; the nearest trap is a supposed reconciliation, which reverses the resentment problem.

Q7. Sur fragmentation accelerated after

- A. Islam Shah's death in 1553.
- B. Babur's death in 1530.
- C. the first Battle of Panipat in 1526.
- D. Sher Shah's accession in 1540.

Answer: A. Explanation: The acceleration follows Islam Shah's 1553 death; the other dates belong to the formation of the earlier political field.

Q8. Humayun recovered Delhi and Agra in

- A. 1540 after Kannauj.
- B. 1555.
- C. 1545 after Kalinjar.
- D. 1556 after Panipat II.

Answer: B. Explanation: Humayun's recovery was in 1555; 1556 marks the next transition, not the recovery itself.

Q9. Sasaram tomb is useful chiefly as

- A. a proof that every Sur revenue office is known.
- B. an exact map of military campaigns.
- C. a bounded example of Sur patronage, legitimacy and material memory.
- D. a full survey of Mughal mansabs.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Sasaram tomb is material evidence of patronage and royal memory; it cannot establish every administrative detail.

Q10. Sarwani needs caution because

- A. a coin catalogue with no narrative purpose.
- B. an official Akbar-era revenue manual.
- C. a contemporary statistical register of highway crime.
- D. a retrospective courtly chronicle can praise and order events selectively.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sarwani can preserve remembered ideals and claims, but courtly retrospective narration is not the same as a statistical audit.

Q11. State capacity is better understood as

- A. a feedback loop among revenue, coin, routes, information and coercion.
- B. a single tax imposed on every village.
- C. a list of unrelated royal charities.
- D. a purely architectural style.

Answer: A. Explanation: State capacity here is relational: fiscal resources, money, circulation, information and force strengthen one another.

Q12. A fort complements a road because

- A. it converts all taxes into cash automatically.
- B. it anchors garrison, storage and frontier control at a strategic node.
- C. it eliminates the need for garrisons.
- D. it serves only as a royal tomb.

Answer: B. Explanation: A fort anchors a corridor by holding troops, stores and a defensible node; a road alone cannot do that.

Q13. Cash assessment can strengthen

- A. the abolition of crop rates.
- B. the ceremonial legitimacy of Din Panah.
- C. the link between revenue demand, markets and recognised coin.
- D. the division of land into Mughal subas.

Answer: C. Explanation: Cash can connect recorded dues and markets through a recognised medium; it does not itself create territorial administration.

Q14. Kind collection can require

- A. the use of horse branding.
- B. the construction of a north-west fort.
- C. the distribution of religious endowments.
- D. harvest knowledge, storage and transport rather than a simple cash formula.

Answer: D. Explanation: Kind collection is tied to crop, harvest, storage and transport; this distinguishes it from monetary or military mechanisms.

Q15. The Multan note is valuable because

- A. it demonstrates that annual measurement was not identical everywhere.
- B. all revenue was collected only in copper.
- C. Sher Shah never measured any land.
- D. Multan was outside the Sur realm.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Multan exception qualifies uniform annual practice; it is not evidence that assessment disappeared or that Multan lay outside the realm.

Q16. A patta does not prove

- A. the use of crop rates called rai.
- B. a British-style direct ryotwari settlement.
- C. the possibility of cash or kind collection.
- D. the survival of village intermediaries.

Answer: B. Explanation: The direct-state conclusion is the error: patta records a claim, while the other three propositions remain part of the actual revenue setting.

Q17. The term jagir/iqta in a Sur answer should signal

- A. a modern land-title registry.
- B. hereditary private ownership without service.
- C. assignment and elite expectation, not automatic ownership of land.
- D. the abolition of noble military obligations.

Answer: C. Explanation: Assignment vocabulary directs attention to revenue and service obligations; ownership and modern title are the closest anachronisms.

Q18. A map claim of Bengal to Indus should be qualified by

- A. the uniform paving of every route.
- B. the immediate abolition of regional chiefs.
- C. Kashmir's inclusion in an exact national boundary.
- D. uneven control, corridor logic and the exclusion of Kashmir.

Answer: D. Explanation: The correct map language preserves Bengal-Indus reach while acknowledging uneven corridors and Kashmir's exclusion.

Q19. Road policy served commerce but also

- A. military logistics, intelligence and surveillance.
- B. a decorative display of royal wealth.
- C. a replacement of every fort by a market.
- D. only the comfort of pilgrims.

Answer: A. Explanation: Roads moved troops and reports as well as merchandise, making military logistics and surveillance the nearest missing dimension.

Q20. Merchant safety was backed by

- A. the removal of village headmen from policing.
- B. local responsibility and the threat of punishment.
- C. the end of customs duties.
- D. a declaration that robbery was no longer punishable.

Answer: B. Explanation: Local responsibility and punishment underpinned safety; no-punishment or no-headman claims invert the mechanism.

Q21. Collective responsibility is analytically important because

- A. a system of coin minting.
- B. an egalitarian benefit with no costs.
- C. it may improve information while imposing coercive burdens on communities.
- D. a rule that made the emperor legally responsible for every theft.

Answer: C. Explanation: Collective responsibility can generate local information but can also impose burdens on non-offenders; that double effect is the core analysis.

Q22. The Sur rupee's later durability indicates

- A. the abolition of market credit.
- B. the absence of older currencies.
- C. a uniform price of grain across the empire.
- D. the importance of standardisation, not an instant universal monetisation.

Answer: D. Explanation: A lasting standard helps transactions but does not prove instant monetisation, price uniformity or disappearance of credit.

Q23. Gold, silver and copper in the source support

- A. a trimetallic monetary framework.
- B. a refusal to use silver in revenue.
- C. a gold-only currency system.
- D. the first European-style paper currency.

Answer: A. Explanation: Gold, silver and copper point to a multiple-metal field; the gold-only option is the closest contradiction.

Q24. A sarkar-pargana description should avoid

- A. calling a pargana a Mughal mansab.
- B. calling every unit a modern province.
- C. treating a village headman as a modern district magistrate.
- D. equating a sarai with a provincial capital.

Answer: B. Explanation: The warning is against modern provincial language; the other terms are likewise category errors rather than medieval territorial analysis.

Q25. The Afghan political field included

- A. a permanent ban on noble counsel.

- B. a democratic election of the sovereign.
- C. noble expectations of honour, service and shares alongside royal assertion.
- D. the absence of revenue assignments.

Answer: C. Explanation: Afghan elite politics involved dignity, service and shares within royal assertion; democracy and no-elite claims are anachronistic.

Q26. Personal supervision can be strong because

- A. it makes currency irrelevant.
- B. it guarantees a stable succession by law.
- C. it removes the need for local information.
- D. it allows rapid auditing and decision, but is difficult for successors to reproduce.

Answer: D. Explanation: Rapid auditing is personal supervision's strength; its succession fragility, not automatic stability, is the critical counterpoint.

Q27. Sher Shah's achievement in a longer process was

- A. systematisation and implementation of interconnected measures.
- B. the first use of any road in India.
- C. the destruction of all Sultanate institutions.
- D. the creation of British-style district administration.

Answer: A. Explanation: Systematisation joins known elements into workable practice; invention-from-nothing and total rupture are the intended traps.

Q28. A comparison with Akbar should state

- A. that Akbar rejected measurement altogether.
- B. continuity with later scale, adaptation and institutional elaboration.
- C. that only coins matter in state-building.
- D. that each ruler used an identical office structure.

Answer: B. Explanation: Continuity must be paired with scale and adaptation; identical structures would erase Akbar's later administrative setting.

Q29. Akbar's dahsala differs from the Sur framework because

- A. a permanent settlement fixed for ten years.
- B. a Sur crop-rate schedule without averaging.
- C. it used a later ten-year average of produce and prices within a broader order.
- D. a system that never used cash.

Answer: C. Explanation: Dahsala's distinction is ten-year averaging of produce and prices; permanent settlement is the closest familiar but false analogy.

Q30. Chehra is best defined as

- A. a customs duty at entry.
- B. a road relay messenger.
- C. a classification of good/middling/bad land.
- D. a descriptive roll used for verification of soldiers.

Answer: D. Explanation: Chehra records soldiers, while the other options belong to revenue, customs and communications.

Q31. Dag is best defined as

- A. horse branding used to check military musters.
- B. a silver coin standard.
- C. a descriptive roll of cavalymen.

- D. a crop-rate register.

Answer: A. Explanation: Dagh marks horses, not persons, coins or crops; chehra is the person-record counterpart.

Q32. The old imperial road terminology warns against

- A. that every route had the same modern highway number.
- B. presenting the GT Road as built from nothing by Sher Shah.
- C. that customs had been abolished.
- D. the need to distinguish Rohtas from Rohtasgarh.

Answer: B. Explanation: The older-route point corrects the invention myth; the named-fort and customs assertions are separate facts, not its core meaning.

Q33. Separate sarai arrangements, where attested, show

- A. that all travellers were taxed at arbitrary rates.
- B. that sarais had no market or relay role.
- C. provisioning for travellers rather than evidence of a secular modern hotel.
- D. that Hindus and Muslims had no distinct accommodation where attested.

Answer: C. Explanation: Separate arrangements are a source-bounded lodging fact; they neither establish a modern hotel nor erase market, dak and control functions.

Q34. Customs simplification should not be turned into

- A. the abolition of entry and sale duties.
- B. the sale of forts to merchants.
- C. a fixed empire-wide percentage rate.
- D. a claim that all commerce was tax-free.

Answer: D. Explanation: Simplification regulates where duties are taken; it does not make trade tax-free or supply an unsupported rate.

Q35. A historical source matrix should compare

- A. chronicle praise, coins, roads/sarais, forts and monuments by evidentiary reach.
- B. a statement that every peasant accepted cash payments.
- C. a direct proof of Kashmiri conquest.
- D. a coins-only source with no social purpose.

Answer: A. Explanation: A source matrix compares what genres can establish; it rejects both chronicle monopoly and naïve material proof.

Q36. A famous quotation about Rajasthan without clear provenance should be

- A. treated as a verified contemporary dispatch.
- B. used only with caution or omitted.
- C. used as a currency weight table.
- D. used to date the Multan exception.

Answer: B. Explanation: Without provenance, a famous saying cannot carry a precise historical claim; treating it as a dispatch is the closest misuse.

Q37. Sher Shah's religion may be described as

- A. a policy of forced conversion documented everywhere.
- B. a refusal to use any Islamic idiom in court.
- C. orthodox without assuming uniform bigotry.
- D. a guarantee that no political violence occurred.

Answer: C. Explanation: Orthodoxy can coexist with non-uniform practice; the all-or-none religious options erase the source's careful qualification.

Q38. The Raisen episode cannot be used to

- A. show that forts had no strategic value.
- B. make roads irrelevant to politics.
- C. prove that Sarwani's praise is false in every respect.
- D. erase violence or prove a timeless uniform policy.

Answer: D. Explanation: A single episode cannot decide uniform policy, but it also cannot be discarded; the other options evade the actual evidence.

Q39. Sur succession weakness reveals

- A. the difference between administrative achievement and dynastic durability.
- B. that Islam Shah's rule preceded Sher Shah's.
- C. that roads and revenue had no legacy.
- D. that Humayun never returned to India.

Answer: A. Explanation: Dynastic collapse and institutional influence operate on different time scales; this is the topic's central distinction.

Q40. The best one-line verdict is

- A. Sher Shah invented a modern bureaucracy in five years.
- B. Sher Shah was a major bridge in state formation, not a fully modern state-builder.
- C. Akbar created every relevant administrative technique without precedent.
- D. Sur rule was historically irrelevant because it was short.

Answer: B. Explanation: The bridge verdict preserves achievement and limits; each alternative collapses the subject into a false origin story.

PART III. Remedial practice: 12 questions

Correct-option audit: **ABCD x 3.**

Q1. The statement 'Sher Shah invented dagh and chehra' is

- A. correct because Akbar had no cavalry records.
- B. uncertain because medieval armies never inspected horses.
- C. incorrect because Alauddin used the controls earlier.
- D. correct because Sher Shah first used them after 1540.

Answer: C. Explanation: Alauddin's Sultanate precedent is decisive; claiming Sher Shah-first destroys the continuous administrative chronology.

Q2. The statement 'Akbar copied every Sur institution unchanged' is

- A. uncertain because roads had no administrative role.
- B. correct because Akbar abolished revenue measurement.
- C. correct because all Sur offices became Mughal offices unchanged.
- D. incorrect because he adapted and systematised within a different scale.

Answer: D. Explanation: Akbar inherited usable precedents but expanded, adapted and systematised them in a different imperial framework.

Q3. The statement 'patta created modern ryotwari' is

- A. incorrect because intermediaries remained central.
- B. uncertain because land was never measured.
- C. correct because patta abolished zamindars.
- D. correct because cash was the only collection mode.

Answer: A. Explanation: Patta records demand; it does not displace local mediators or prove cash-only, perfectly measured direct settlement.

Q4. The statement 'the GT Road began from nothing under Sher Shah' is

- A. correct because no imperial route existed before 1540.
- B. incorrect because he restored/improved an older route.
- C. correct because the road connected only Agra and Delhi.
- D. uncertain because roads did not affect trade.

Answer: B. Explanation: The old-route language means restoration/improvement; the other claims ignore the Indus-Sonargaon corridor and its commercial purpose.

Q5. The statement 'sarais were welfare-only buildings' is

- A. uncertain because markets could not exist near roads.
- B. correct because dak began only under the British.
- C. incorrect because they linked lodging, markets, news, trade and control.
- D. correct because sarais housed travellers only.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sarais combined lodging with markets, relay, security and state observation; the welfare-only label strips away their political economy.

Q6. The statement 'one-third proves identical practice everywhere' is

- A. uncertain because local headmen were excluded.
- B. correct because Multan was never assessed.
- C. correct because rai fixed every local crop identically.
- D. incorrect because local mediation and the Multan exception qualify it.

Answer: D. Explanation: The one-third formulation is qualified by local practice and the Multan exception; uniformity is the precise mistake.

Q7. The statement 'the rupee was the first silver coin in India' is

- A. incorrect because earlier silver coinage existed.
- B. uncertain because standards never affect exchange.
- C. correct because only copper circulated in the Sur empire.
- D. correct because silver was unknown before Sher Shah.

Answer: A. Explanation: The correction is standardisation, not invention: earlier silver coinage and a trimetallic setting are essential context.

Q8. The statement 'Rohtas and Rohtasgarh are the same fort' is

- A. correct because both guarded the Gakhhar frontier.
- B. incorrect because one is in present-day Pakistan and the other in Bihar.
- C. uncertain because place-names do not matter in history.
- D. correct because both lie in Bengal.

Answer: B. Explanation: The names mask different locations and functions: north-west Rohtas and Bihar's Rohtasgarh must be separated.

Q9. The statement 'Puran Mal proves uniform Sur persecution' is

- A. correct because every Sur policy targeted one religious community.
- B. uncertain because political calculation never uses religious language.
- C. incorrect because the episode needs a political-religious reading.
- D. correct because the episode contained no violence.

Answer: C. Explanation: The episode is politically and religiously entangled; neither a uniform-policy inference nor erasure of violence is defensible.

Q10. The statement 'Sher Shah created Akbar's subas' is

- A. uncertain because territorial terms cannot be studied.
- B. correct because Akbar's twelve subas existed from 1540.
- C. correct because pargana meant a modern state capital.
- D. incorrect because Sur sarkar/shiq-pargana terms require their own setting.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sur sarkar/shiq-pargana vocabulary belongs to its own setting; importing Akbar's later subas is the periodisation error.

Q11. The statement 'Sarwani's praise proves crime vanished' is

- A. incorrect because rhetoric and coercive mechanisms must be assessed together.
- B. uncertain because merchants never travelled by road.
- C. correct because coercive policing was absent.
- D. correct because a court chronicle is a crime census.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sarwani's rhetoric must be read with the mechanisms of responsibility and punishment, not treated as literal universal measurement.

Q12. The statement 'Sur collapse makes all Sur reforms meaningless' is

- A. uncertain because succession never affects governance.
- B. incorrect because legacy and dynastic durability are separate questions.
- C. correct because Akbar had no administrative predecessors.
- D. correct because only dynasties, not institutions, matter.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sur failure in succession does not erase roads, revenue or monetary legacy; it reveals their limited durability under personal rule.

Semantic-completeness coverage drills - Medieval Topic 14

Drill	Prompt	Minimum answer route	Fatal trap
A	Critique Sher Shah sources.	Sarwani/Nizamuddin/Mughal -> coin/inscription/fabric -> later colonial memory	neutral manual
B	Map campaign/extent.	Bihar/Bengal -> Malwa/Raisen/Sammel/Kalinjar -> core/frontier/tribute	uniform empire
C	Explain Afghan state.	monarchy -> nobles/clans/assignments -> sarkar/pargana/village	tribal democracy
D	Audit revenue.	measure/classify/rai/share/patta/qabuliyat/cash-kind -> intermediaries/exceptions	ryotwari/universal rate
E	Analyse roads/money.	old corridors -> sarai/well/dak/security -> rupiya/dam/gold/mints -> limits	inventions
F	Assess army/justice.	recruitment/dagh/chehra/cavalry/forts -> policing/collective responsibility	modern departments
G	Evaluate religion/architecture.	Raisen/accommodation -> Sasaram/Purana Qila/Rohtas phases	tolerant/persecutor label
H	Explain legacy/collapse.	Islam Shah -> civil wars/Hemu -> 1555 -> Sur adaptation versus Mughal change	finished blueprint

PYQ status: zero direct CSE routes. The Topic-16 administrative hierarchy route remains adjacent and is not reproduced as an exact Sher Shah question.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART IV. Original Mains practice: 10 examiner-grade solved answers

Mains 1. Trace Farid/Sher Khan's rise from local administrative exposure to the creation of Sur sovereignty.
10 marks | 150 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: Farid's route to sovereignty was a process of administrative learning, regional resource mobilisation and strategic scale-up, not a sudden personal miracle.

Named evidence and analysis:

- Exposure in his father's jagirs/parganas supplied practical knowledge of assessment and intermediaries. **What it proves:** The sequence shows that local administrative knowledge and a connected Bihar-Bengal field made military victory governable.
- Bihar politics gave a regional Afghan base; Surajgarh (1534) and Bengal/Gaur expanded resources. **What it proves:** The sequence shows that local administrative knowledge and a connected Bihar-Bengal field made military victory governable.
- Chausa (1539) and Kannauj (1540) converted regional capacity into the displacement of Humayun. **What it proves:** The sequence shows that local administrative knowledge and a connected Bihar-Bengal field made military victory governable.

Qualification: Battle detail should remain bounded; Afghan politics were coalition-based rather than a timeless ethnic bloc.

Verdict: Sher Shah's rise demonstrates how regional capacity could become imperial sovereignty when linked to route, resource and elite control.

Why this earns marks: A high-scoring response does not begin at Chausa. It makes the administrative apprenticeship and Bihar resource base causal, then uses Surajgarh, Bengal/Gaur and the two battles as a scale sequence. This prevents a generic 'brave commander' biography.

Demand decoding: The directive **trace** requires a direct position on "Mains 1. Trace Farid/Sher Khan's rise from local administrative exposure to the creation of...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 1. Trace Farid/Sher Khan's rise from local administrative exposure to the creation of...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 2. Assess Sher Shah's state capacity as an interlocking system rather than a list of reforms.
15 marks | 200 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: Sher Shah's distinctive contribution was to make fiscal, monetary, communicative and coercive measures reinforce one another.

Named evidence and analysis:

- Measurement, classification, rai and a generally one-third claim made revenue more legible. **What it proves:** Revenue could fund force; force and information secured roads; roads enlarged trade and taxable circulation.
- The standardised silver rupee supported payments and market confidence. **What it proves:** Revenue could fund force; force and information secured roads; roads enlarged trade and taxable circulation.

- The restored Indus-Sonargaon route, other roads, sarais and dak joined movement to information. **What it proves:** Revenue could fund force; force and information secured roads; roads enlarged trade and taxable circulation.
- Merchant security and collective local responsibility made routes administratively usable. **What it proves:** Revenue could fund force; force and information secured roads; roads enlarged trade and taxable circulation.

Qualification: Capacity remained mediated by local elites and dependent on personal supervision; it was not a modern direct state.

Verdict: The Sur system was an unusually coherent practical feedback loop, but one with personal and local limits.

Why this earns marks: Marks come from connecting, rather than listing, revenue, money, routes, news and coercion. The feedback-loop formulation demonstrates causation. A top answer also says why concentrated direction makes this capacity difficult to reproduce after 1545.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Mains 2. Assess Sher Shah's state capacity as an interlocking system rather than a list of...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 2. Assess Sher Shah's state capacity as an interlocking system rather than a list of...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 3. Examine Sher Shah's revenue system. Did it protect the peasant from arbitrary demand?

15 marks | 200 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: The revenue programme increased predictability through measurement and records, but it also made extraction more systematic and remained locally mediated.

Named evidence and analysis:

- Sown land was measured and classified as good, middling and bad. **What it proves:** Records could make a demand knowable to both collector and cultivator, reducing room for arbitrary multiplication, while simultaneously improving the state's fiscal grip.
- Average yield and crop rates (rai) informed a generally one-third state claim. **What it proves:** Records could make a demand knowable to both collector and cultivator, reducing room for arbitrary multiplication, while simultaneously improving the state's fiscal grip.
- Patta recorded area, crop and demand; local headmen and zamindars still mattered. **What it proves:** Records could make a demand knowable to both collector and cultivator, reducing room for arbitrary multiplication, while simultaneously improving the state's fiscal grip.
- Cash/kind paths and the Multan exception show uneven operational practice. **What it proves:** Records could make a demand knowable to both collector and cultivator, reducing room for arbitrary multiplication, while simultaneously improving the state's fiscal grip.

Qualification: It is wrong to call it modern ryotwari or to make one-third universal in every place and crop.

Verdict: Sher Shah advanced fiscal legibility and some predictability, not a direct peasant-state settlement.

Why this earns marks: The examiner should see two sides of the same record: a known demand may restrain local arbitrariness, while measurement strengthens the fiscal claim. The answer earns balance only if it retains headmen/zamindars, cash/kind variation and the Multan qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Mains 3. Examine Sher Shah's revenue system. Did it protect the peasant from arbitrary...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified

verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 3. Examine Sher Shah's revenue system. Did it protect the peasant from arbitrary...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 4. How did roads, sarais and customs measures combine commerce with imperial control under Sher Shah?

20 marks | 250 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: The Sur circulation system supported commerce precisely because it also made people, goods and information more visible and movable for the state.

Named evidence and analysis:

- Sher Shah restored/improved the older Indus-Sonargaon route and maintained other strategic roads. **What it proves:** A corridor becomes commercially useful when risk and transaction barriers fall; the same corridor moves soldiers, carries reports, supplies forts and permits surveillance.
- Sarais at the stated two-karoh interval offered lodging, markets and relay support. **What it proves:** A corridor becomes commercially useful when risk and transaction barriers fall; the same corridor moves soldiers, carries reports, supplies forts and permits surveillance.
- Dak/news arrangements shortened informational distance. **What it proves:** A corridor becomes commercially useful when risk and transaction barriers fall; the same corridor moves soldiers, carries reports, supplies forts and permits surveillance.
- Customs simplification at entry and sale reduced proliferating levies without abolishing fiscal claims. **What it proves:** A corridor becomes commercially useful when risk and transaction barriers fall; the same corridor moves soldiers, carries reports, supplies forts and permits surveillance.
- Merchant safety relied on local responsibility backed by punishment. **What it proves:** A corridor becomes commercially useful when risk and transaction barriers fall; the same corridor moves soldiers, carries reports, supplies forts and permits surveillance.

Qualification: Do not invent rates, kilometre conversions or a welfare-only story. Network reach and quality were not uniform.

Verdict: Road policy was a political economy of circulation: trade was fostered, but also rendered governable.

Why this earns marks: A good answer starts with circulation, not charity. It links route restoration, sarais, dak, customs and policing to both lower transaction friction and greater state visibility. It loses marks if it supplies invented tariff rates or modern kilometre conversions.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Mains 4. How did roads, sarais and customs measures combine commerce with imperial control...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 4. How did roads, sarais and customs measures combine commerce with imperial control...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or

scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 5. Why is Sher Shah's silver rupee best understood as standardisation rather than invention?

10 marks | 150 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: Sher Shah's monetary importance lies in a durable standard of fine silver currency, not in the first appearance of silver money.

Named evidence and analysis:

- The source associates him with a standardised fine silver rupee. **What it proves:** A recognised standard reduced uncertainty in revenue payment, salary and exchange across routes, complementing roads and assessment.
- Gold, silver and copper indicate a connected trimetallic field. **What it proves:** A recognised standard reduced uncertainty in revenue payment, salary and exchange across routes, complementing roads and assessment.
- Earlier silver coins existed, so chronological overclaim is false. **What it proves:** A recognised standard reduced uncertainty in revenue payment, salary and exchange across routes, complementing roads and assessment.

Qualification: It did not eliminate local credit, older monies, barter or regional price differences; exact weight/fineness should not be invented.

Verdict: The rupee's significance is institutional reliability and later durability, not monetary creation ex nihilo.

Why this earns marks: The essential discriminator is chronological modesty. State standardisation, name the trimetallic context and explain the fiscal-commercial mechanism. Avoid numerical fineness claims unless supplied by a cited source and reject the slogan that the rupee was money's first appearance.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Mains 5. Why is Sher Shah's silver rupee best understood as standardisation rather than...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 5. Why is Sher Shah's silver rupee best understood as standardisation rather than...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 6. Discuss Sher Shah's law-and-order policy without romanticising it.

15 marks | 200 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: Sher Shah's reputation for safe roads rested on a real administrative logic of local responsibility and stern enforcement, but its coercive costs must be retained.

Named evidence and analysis:

- Sources credit action against robbers, dacoits and recalcitrant zamindars. **What it proves:** Responsibility could mobilise local knowledge and deter concealment, making merchants more willing to travel and pay. Yet collective liability may punish communities for offences they did not personally commit.
- Village headmen and zamindars were made responsible in policing. **What it proves:** Responsibility could mobilise local knowledge and deter concealment, making merchants more willing to travel and pay. Yet collective liability may punish communities for offences they did not personally commit.
- Sarwani's old-woman safety image records a celebrated ideal and reputation. **What it proves:** Responsibility could mobilise local knowledge and deter concealment, making merchants more willing to travel and pay. Yet collective liability may punish communities for offences they did not personally commit.
- Roads, sarais and customs policy gave security an economic setting. **What it proves:** Responsibility could mobilise local knowledge and deter concealment, making merchants more willing to travel and pay. Yet collective

liability may punish communities for offences they did not personally commit.

Qualification: Courtly praise is not a crime statistic, and security was not equally experienced by all groups or places.

Verdict: The policy fused commercial benefit with surveillance and coercion rather than embodying benevolence alone.

Why this earns marks: The answer must neither quote Sarwani as literal proof nor dismiss security as rhetoric. It should show how responsibility produced information and deterrence, then make collective punishment an ethical and administrative qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Mains 6. Discuss Sher Shah's law-and-order policy without romanticising it.”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 6. Discuss Sher Shah's law-and-order policy without romanticising it.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 7. Place Sher Shah's dagh and chehra measures in their correct institutional chronology.

10 marks | 150 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: Sher Shah revived and adapted earlier cavalry-verification controls; he should be placed between Sultanate precedent and Mughal systematisation.

Named evidence and analysis:

- Alauddin Khalji introduced or used dagh and chehra in the Sultanate. **What it proves:** Branding and descriptive rolls addressed the recurring information problem of fictitious musters and unreliable cavalry claims.
- Sher Shah used direct recruitment and inspection within personal supervision. **What it proves:** Branding and descriptive rolls addressed the recurring information problem of fictitious musters and unreliable cavalry claims.
- Akbar later systematised such controls within mansabdari and jagir arrangements. **What it proves:** Branding and descriptive rolls addressed the recurring information problem of fictitious musters and unreliable cavalry claims.

Qualification: Continuity is not sameness: each ruler used controls within a different fiscal, elite and administrative framework.

Verdict: The correct verdict rejects both the Sher Shah-first and Akbar-first myths while explaining a durable state problem.

Why this earns marks: Chronology is the value addition: Alauddin, then Sher Shah, then Akbar. The answer must explain the shared verification problem and briefly state why the later mansab setting differs from a Sur army under personal supervision.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Mains 7. Place Sher Shah's dagh and chehra measures in their correct institutional...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 7. Place Sher Shah's dagh and chehra measures in their correct institutional...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 8. Evaluate the tension between Afghan noble expectations and Sher Shah's personal despotism.

20 marks | 250 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: Sur rule combined strong monarchical assertion with an Afghan political field in which nobles retained expectations of assignment, honour and participation.

Named evidence and analysis:

- Sher Shah's personal supervision made revenue, army and justice responsive to the sovereign. **What it proves:** Personal direction can rapidly coordinate a new empire, but it makes continuity dependent on a ruler's capacity and the willingness of powerful men to accept constraint.
- Iqta/jagir-like expectations linked elite service to revenue and status. **What it proves:** Personal direction can rapidly coordinate a new empire, but it makes continuity dependent on a ruler's capacity and the willingness of powerful men to accept constraint.
- Islam Shah's effort to assert monarchy over nobles continued centralisation but sharpened resentment. **What it proves:** Personal direction can rapidly coordinate a new empire, but it makes continuity dependent on a ruler's capacity and the willingness of powerful men to accept constraint.
- Fragmentation after Islam Shah's death in 1553 exposed the limits of concentrated authority. **What it proves:** Personal direction can rapidly coordinate a new empire, but it makes continuity dependent on a ruler's capacity and the willingness of powerful men to accept constraint.

Qualification: Do not reduce this to 'tribal equality' or deny the throne's coercive power. Faction, succession, regional resources and military command all mattered.

Verdict: Sher Shah achieved a formidable but personally weighted balance; the succession crisis showed why administrative efficiency and dynastic durability were different tests.

Why this earns marks: This needs an institutional, not ethnic, explanation. Strong answers balance monarchical coercion, assignments, noble expectations, Islam Shah's centralisation and post-1553 faction. A simplistic 'Afghan tribalism caused collapse' line is specifically inadequate.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on "Mains 8. Evaluate the tension between Afghan noble expectations and Sher Shah's personal...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 8. Evaluate the tension between Afghan noble expectations and Sher Shah's personal...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 9. Examine the Puran Mal/Raisen episode as a problem of religion and politics in Sur rule.

15 marks | 200 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: The Raisen episode demands an ethical acknowledgement of violence and a historically specific reading of political calculation and religious language.

Named evidence and analysis:

- Sher Shah is described as orthodox but not generally bigoted in the assigned source. **What it proves:** Religious idiom could legitimise or intensify political action; political security and elite pressure could shape its application. Analysis must not dissolve either dimension.
- Puran Mal held a powerful fort and the episode followed political confrontation. **What it proves:** Religious idiom could legitimise or intensify political action; political security and elite pressure could shape its application. Analysis

must not dissolve either dimension.

- The source treats the act as political with religious gloss and records treacherous violence after an oath. **What it proves:** Religious idiom could legitimise or intensify political action; political security and elite pressure could shape its application. Analysis must not dissolve either dimension.
- No general pattern of temple destruction is supplied by this evidence. **What it proves:** Religious idiom could legitimise or intensify political action; political security and elite pressure could shape its application. Analysis must not dissolve either dimension.

Qualification: One episode cannot prove a uniform policy, but administrative admiration cannot excuse or erase the violence. Famous quotation traditions require provenance caution.

Verdict: The best conclusion is neither blanket exoneration nor blanket communal generalisation, but a sourced, qualified political-religious judgement.

Why this earns marks: The directive demands an interpretive answer. It should keep political calculation and religious language in the same frame, use Raisen specifically, acknowledge the reported betrayal/violence and reject both uniform-persecution and pure-administrative-exoneration stories.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Mains 9. Examine the Puran Mal/Raisen episode as a problem of religion and politics in Sur...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 9. Examine the Puran Mal/Raisen episode as a problem of religion and politics in Sur...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 10. Compare Sher Shah and Akbar as state-builders. Was Akbar merely an imitator?

20 marks | 250 words

Model solution

Claim / thesis: Akbar inherited and adapted important Sur precedents, but his longer reign, larger framework and institutional elaboration make mere imitation untenable.

Named evidence and analysis:

- Sher Shah used measurement, rai, patta and a generally one-third claim; Akbar's 1580 dahsala used ten-year averages of produce and prices. **What it proves:** Comparison on these axes reveals evolution: common problems of verification and revenue were solved through increasingly articulated institutions, not copied unchanged.
- Sher Shah's standardised rupee and route/sarai system aided circulation; Akbar worked within a larger imperial structure. **What it proves:** Comparison on these axes reveals evolution: common problems of verification and revenue were solved through increasingly articulated institutions, not copied unchanged.
- Dagh-chehra show Alauddin -> Sher Shah -> Akbar continuity rather than Akbar-first invention. **What it proves:** Comparison on these axes reveals evolution: common problems of verification and revenue were solved through increasingly articulated institutions, not copied unchanged.
- Sher Shah's sarkar/pargana milieu differs from Akbar's suba and mansab-jagir order. **What it proves:** Comparison on these axes reveals evolution: common problems of verification and revenue were solved through increasingly articulated institutions, not copied unchanged.
- Sur personal supervision and Afghan elite tension contrast with Akbar's longer composite ruling-class strategy. **What it proves:** Comparison on these axes reveals evolution: common problems of verification and revenue were solved through increasingly articulated institutions, not copied unchanged.

Qualification: Neither rupture nor hero-worship works. Zabt was not universally identical even under Akbar, and Sur practices were not an impersonal modern bureaucracy.

Verdict: Sher Shah was a crucial bridge and precursor; Akbar's achievement was adaptation, scale and durable systematisation, not passive imitation.

Why this earns marks: A comparison earns marks by using axes rather than a two-column fact dump. Revenue method, territorial scale, cavalry checks and ruling-class organisation should each support the central verdict: precursor and adaptation, not copy or rupture.

Evidence, comparison and source drills

1. **Evidence clinic.** [ANALYSIS] When a claim concerns an institution, first name the practice, then identify who carried it out, what information it produced, and what social or temporal condition limited it. For Sher Shah, this prevents roads becoming mere construction, patta becoming a colonial settlement, or safety becoming benevolent rhetoric.
2. **Comparison drill.** [ANALYSIS] Ask a comparison question on an axis rather than by ruler-list: revenue calculation, territorial vocabulary, currency, transport, military verification, ruling class and succession. Then distinguish precedent, adaptation and scale. This method protects the answer from both the innovation myth and the copying myth.
3. **Source drill.** [ANALYSIS] A chronicle can preserve a ruler's ideal, sequence and remembered practice; a coin can show a monetary standard; a fort or sarai can show material investment; none alone measures uniform implementation. Write what each source can establish before drawing a wider inference.

Demand decoding: The directive **compare** requires a direct position on "Mains 10. Compare Sher Shah and Akbar as state-builders. Was Akbar merely an imitator?", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 10. Compare Sher Shah and Akbar as state-builders. Was Akbar merely an imitator?", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.